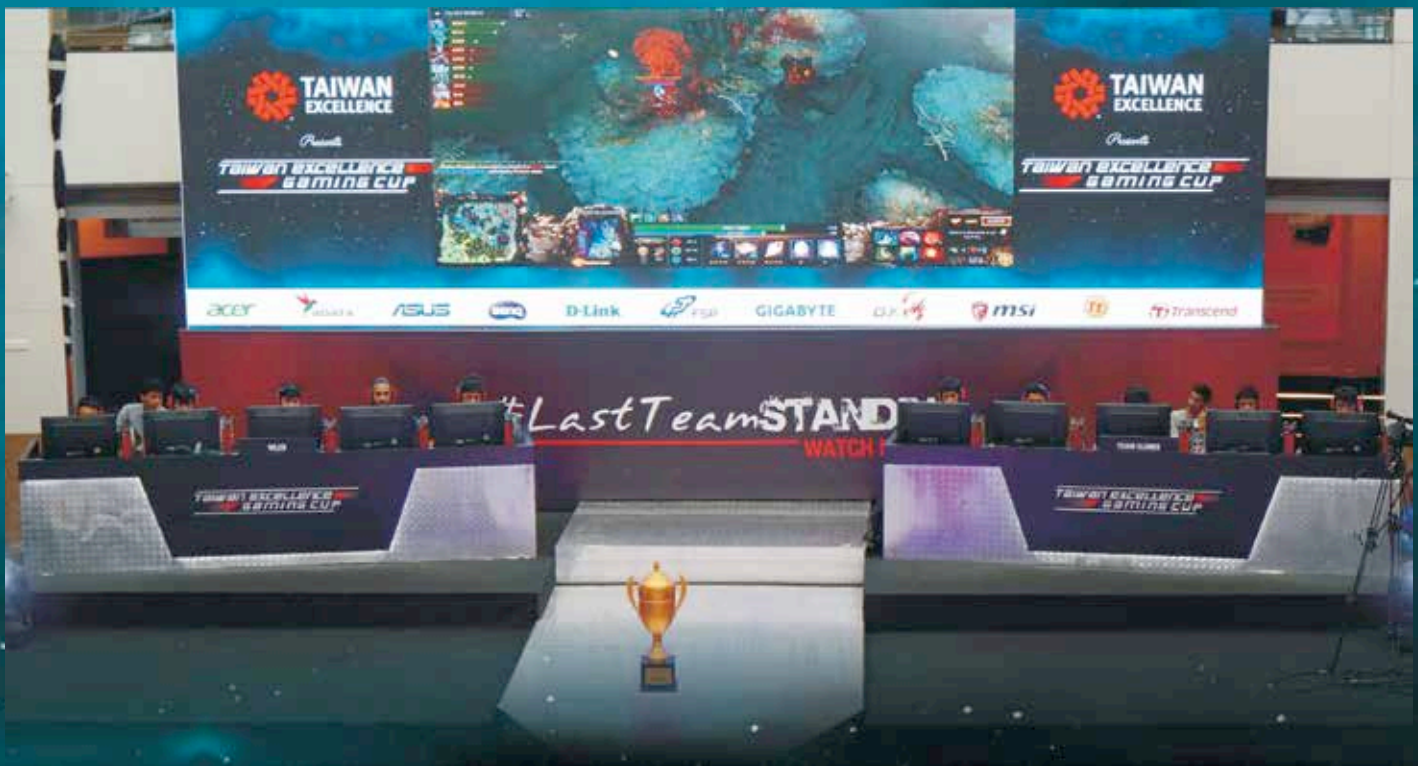




The gaming segment in India is experiencing a radical shift.” Brands are jumping into the fray as Mr. Grewal says, “You also find a lot of companies that manufacture gaming components, gear and software supporting gamers financially, while also offering lucrative platforms to play and win handsome prizes.”

Gaming far and wide:

Recently there were reports that gaming is picking up even in the small towns of India. A tabloid carried a story about a cyber cafe in Ichalkaranji, a town near the Maharashtra-Karnataka border, where the popularity of gaming is hitting the roof. The cafe owner was quoted as saying that when they first started gaming at the cafe six years ago, the popular games were single-player ones like Age of Empires or Grand Theft Auto: Vice City, but with internet speeds improving over the last two years, almost everyone now plays online games like DOTA and Counter-Strike.

Of course, this could be a one-off case because it is not easy for cyber cafes to survive in India. Mr. Singh explains, “It is difficult

that they charge the customers cannot be too high. Since returns are not too high, it could be tough for them.”

Big games, big money:

But with an enormous youth population and rapidly growing broadband internet penetration, many market analysts predict that India is en route to become a considerable gaming market. Brands too agree that the demand for world-class gaming products is growing year-on-year. Mr. Grewal says this is certainly an offshoot of the rising popularity of gaming in India and we are seeing a market boom for all product types that are relevant to gaming, whether it's gear, peripherals, software, and hardware.

Affordability does play a role too because many complain that a big challenge faced in India is the high import duty on gaming products resulting in excessive prices, sometimes making games unaffordable for the average Indian consumer. But as Mr. Grewal says, prices for products affect only to some extent the people who are enthusiastic and passionate about gaming, “They are tech-savvy, and most of them know precisely about the features and models that they are looking for. If any particular model they desire, costs a few bucks more, that's not going to stop them from getting the product. They may postpone the time to buy, but surely will not withdraw their decision from buying.”

Most Taiwanese gaming brands say that their existing gaming products have found many takers. BenQ recently launched two new monitors, the 27-inch Quad-HD, AMD Freesync supported XL2730Z and the 24-inch XL2430T HD widescreen in the price range of Rs 36,000 to Rs 50,000. The demand was so high that the company ran out of stock. “We had to call for more stock because of such high demand,” says Mr. Singh.

ASUS launched the ROG GL552 priced at Rs 70,999 that has been hailed by enthusiasts as one of the few good gaming laptops in India that is on the lower side of the Rs 1 lakh and probably affordable to passionate gamers. Says Mr. Su, “We see a lot of demand from beginners who do not need a professional gaming machine but at the same time would need a configuration that would help them enjoy their gaming experience. Our whole objective was to allow these beginners and entry level gamers to join the ROG league that were originally held back to due price.”



for cyber cafes to sustain here because they may find it hard to recover money they invest in gaming products. The per hour cost